

The African Entrepreneur's Complete Guide to U.S. Business Formation

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THE AFRICAN ENTREPRENEUR'S

Complete Guide to

U.S. BUSINESS FORMATION

*How to register a U.S. LLC or Corporation and build a globally competitive business
from anywhere in Africa.*

FOREWORD

A Message to the African Builder

You built something real. Maybe it started in Lagos, Nairobi, Accra, Johannesburg, or Kigali. Maybe it runs entirely online. Whatever it is, you have arrived at the same wall that thousands of African entrepreneurs hit every year: the world's most powerful economy is right there, and yet accessing it, banking in it, getting paid through it, being trusted by it, feels like it was designed for someone else.

It was not designed for you. But you can design your way into it.

This guide is your blueprint. It is direct, practical, and written specifically for the African entrepreneur who wants to do business with the world, not just survive in a local market. Whether you want to sell software to American clients, run an e-commerce brand, offer professional services, or build the next African-born unicorn, a U.S. business entity is one of the most powerful tools available to you.

By the end of this guide, you will know exactly how to form your U.S. company, get your EIN, open Stripe and Mercury accounts, handle taxes correctly, and launch in 90 days or fewer. Let's get started.

CHAPTER 1

The American Opportunity: Why the U.S. Market Is Worth It

The United States is, by almost every measure, the most accessible major economy for foreign entrepreneurs. It has the world's largest consumer market, the most trusted payment infrastructure, and a legal system that non-residents can use without ever setting foot on American soil. For an African entrepreneur, this is not a dream, it is a documented, repeatable process.

The Global Trust Signal

When a client in London, Dubai, or Singapore sees a U.S.-registered LLC on an invoice, something changes. The deal feels safer. The payment terms are clearer. The risk feels lower. This is not about abandoning your African identity, it is about adding a layer of international credibility that opens doors your current entity structure may not.

A U.S. entity also unlocks payment gateways that are simply unavailable to African-registered businesses. Stripe, PayPal Business, Braintree, and Shopify Payments all require a U.S. or supported-country entity. With a U.S. LLC, you can accept USD, EUR, GBP, and dozens of other currencies from customers worldwide, with the funds landing in a U.S. bank account you control.

What a U.S. Company Actually Gives You

- Access to Stripe, Stripe Atlas, Mercury, Brex, Relay, and other fintech platforms
- A U.S. bank account to receive wire transfers, ACH payments, and checks
- The ability to sign U.S.-compliant contracts with American clients
- A credible legal structure for raising investment from U.S. investors
- Separation of your personal African assets from business liability
- A path to international expansion from a stable, respected jurisdiction

Key Insight

You do not need a U.S. visa, a U.S. address, or a U.S. citizen partner to form a U.S. LLC. Non-residents can own 100% of a U.S. LLC in most states.

The African Diaspora Advantage

Africa's tech and entrepreneurship ecosystem is producing world-class talent. Flutterwave, Paystack, Andela, Wave, and dozens of other companies began with African founders who leveraged U.S. incorporation as part of their growth strategy. The difference between the companies that got there and the ones that didn't was not talent, it was infrastructure. This guide is your infrastructure.

CHAPTER 2

Understanding U.S. Business Structures and Choosing the Right Entity

Before you register anything, you need to understand what you are registering. The U.S. offers several business structures, but for African entrepreneurs operating internationally, two dominate: the LLC and the C-Corporation. Each has distinct advantages depending on your goals.

The LLC (Limited Liability Company)

The LLC is the most popular structure for non-U.S. residents starting a U.S. business. It is flexible, relatively inexpensive to maintain, and offers strong personal liability protection. A single-member LLC owned by a non-U.S. person is classified as a 'disregarded entity' by the IRS, meaning the tax flows through to you as the owner, and you only pay U.S. tax on income that is 'effectively connected' to the U.S.

For most service-based businesses, digital product companies, and freelancers operating outside the U.S., this means you may owe little to no U.S. federal income tax, though you absolutely must file the correct information returns (more on this in Chapter 6).

The C-Corporation

If you plan to raise venture capital from U.S. investors, Delaware C-Corp is the gold standard. Nearly every U.S. venture fund and accelerator (including Y Combinator) requires portfolio companies to be Delaware C-Corps. The trade-off is double taxation, the corporation pays federal corporate tax (21%), and shareholders pay tax again on dividends. However, if you are raising equity funding, this structure is almost non-negotiable.

Side-by-Side Comparison

Factor	LLC vs C-Corp
Setup Cost	\$50–\$500 (state fees) (LLC) \$200–\$800+ (state fees) (C-Corp)
Ongoing Costs	Lower (LLC) Higher (registered agent, annual reports) (C-Corp)
Tax Treatment	Pass-through (owner pays) (LLC) Double taxation possible (C-Corp)
VC Investment Ready	Sometimes, with conversion (LLC) Yes, preferred by VCs (C-Corp)
Best For	Services, SaaS, e-commerce, freelancers (LLC) Startups seeking U.S. equity investment (C-Corp)
Complexity	Low to Medium (LLC)

Factor	LLC vs C-Corp
	Medium to High (C-Corp)

For simplicity, the table above has been condensed. The key decision rule is this: if you need U.S. venture capital, form a Delaware C-Corp. If you are building a profitable, cash-flow-positive business, the LLC is almost always the right choice.

The S-Corporation: Not for You

S-Corporations are not available to non-U.S. residents. Do not let anyone recommend one. If you see this suggestion from a formation service, walk away.

Sole Proprietorships and Partnerships

Sole proprietorships offer zero liability protection. Partnerships require at least two people and add complexity. For an African entrepreneur building a U.S. presence, neither of these is recommended as a starting structure.

Our Recommendation

Start with a single-member Wyoming or Delaware LLC. It gives you liability protection, payment access, banking options, and a clean tax structure. If you raise a funding round, convert to a Delaware C-Corp at that time

CHAPTER 3

State Selection Strategy: Where in America Should You Register?

The United States has 50 states, and each has its own business formation rules, fees, and tax regimes. You do not need to register in the state where you live, because you live in Africa. You need to register in the state that gives you the best legal and financial environment for your international business.

The top three states for non-resident founders are Delaware, Wyoming, and New Mexico. Here is how to think about each.

Delaware: The Corporate Capital of America

Delaware is home to more than 65% of Fortune 500 companies and the majority of U.S. startups. Its Court of Chancery is a specialized business court with centuries of corporate precedent, and investors love this predictability. Delaware LLCs cost around \$90 to form and require a registered agent.

If you plan to raise money from U.S. investors, take on employees, or eventually go public, Delaware is the right answer. If you are running a lean, profitable international service business, it may be overkill.

Wyoming: The Privacy Champion

Wyoming has no state income tax, extremely low formation fees (\$100), strong privacy protections for LLC owners, and one of the most business-friendly legal environments in the country. You are not required to list member names publicly. Wyoming is ideal for entrepreneurs who want maximum privacy, low cost, and a clean operating structure.

New Mexico: The Anonymous LLC Option

New Mexico is one of the few states where LLCs are not required to file an annual report, and member names are not public record. Formation fees are among the lowest in the country. For entrepreneurs who prioritize privacy and minimal maintenance costs, New Mexico deserves serious consideration.

The Bottom Line on State Selection

Choose Delaware if investors are in your future. Choose Wyoming if you want low cost, high privacy, and a lean operational structure. Choose New Mexico if you want the lowest possible maintenance burden and maximum anonymity.

Do You Need to Register in Multiple States?

No, not to start. You only need to 'foreign qualify' in another state if you have physical operations, employees, or offices there. Since you are operating from Africa, one state registration is sufficient for international business.

CHAPTER 4

The Formation Process: Step-by-Step Registration in the U.S.

Forming a U.S. LLC as a non-resident is a documented, legal process that thousands of African entrepreneurs have completed successfully. Here is the exact sequence of steps, from decision to active company.

Step 1: Choose Your State and Entity Type

Use the framework from Chapter 3. Have your choice locked before you proceed. Changing your state later means dissolving and reforming, which is an avoidable expense.

Step 2: Choose a Company Name

Your company name must be unique within your chosen state and must include a required designator such as LLC, L.L.C., or Limited Liability Company. You can check name availability for free on the Secretary of State's website for Delaware (corp.delaware.gov), Wyoming (sos.wyo.gov), or New Mexico (portal.sos.state.nm.us).

- Avoid names that imply banking, insurance, or government affiliation unless licensed
- Generic names are fine. 'Greenfield Digital LLC' works perfectly
- You can use a different 'doing business as' (DBA) name once registered

Step 3: Appoint a Registered Agent

Every U.S. LLC must have a registered agent. A person or company with a physical U.S. address who receives legal and government documents on your behalf. As a non-resident, you will need to hire a registered agent service.

Step 4: File Articles of Organization

This is the official formation document. You file it with the Secretary of State. For Delaware, this is called the Certificate of Formation. Filing can be done online, by mail, or through a formation service. The filing fee is paid to the state, not to your registered agent.

Required information typically includes: company name, registered agent name and address, member/manager names (varies by state and privacy preferences), and the purpose of the business.

Step 5: Get Your EIN (Employer Identification Number)

The EIN is your company's tax identification number, issued by the IRS. You cannot open a U.S. bank account, sign up for Stripe, or file taxes without it. This is non-negotiable.

Non-residents can apply for an EIN by fax or mail using IRS Form SS-4. International applicants can also call the IRS Business Specialty Tax Line. The EIN is typically assigned during the call. There is no fee.

Important Note

You do not need an ITIN (Individual Taxpayer Identification Number) to get an EIN. The EIN is assigned to the business entity, not to you personally. Mark 'Other' as your business type and write 'non-resident alien' in the description field on Form SS-4.

Step 6: Create Your Operating Agreement

The Operating Agreement is an internal document that outlines how your LLC is governed. Even as a single-member LLC, you need one. Banks and payment processors often ask for it. It does not need to be filed with any government office. You can create one using free templates from sites like Rocket Lawyer or hire a lawyer to draft a custom version.

Step 7: Get a Virtual U.S. Address (Optional but Recommended)

Many payment platforms, banks, and clients will ask for a U.S. business address. A virtual mailbox service (Earth Class Mail, PostScan Mail, iPostal1) gives you a real U.S. street address (not a P.O. box) for \$10–\$30/month. This address can appear on your website, invoices, and business cards.

Step 8: Verify and Store Your Documents

Once formed, you should have: Articles of Organization (or Certificate of Formation), your EIN confirmation letter (CP 575), Operating Agreement, and proof of registered agent appointment. Store digital copies securely in Google Drive or Dropbox. You will need these for banking and every significant business transaction.

CHAPTER 5

Banking & Finance: Opening U.S. Accounts as a Foreign Business Owner

This chapter is where many African entrepreneurs get stuck. Traditional U.S. banks, Bank of America, Chase, Wells Fargo etc., require in-person visits for account opening. Since you are operating from Africa, you need fintech-first solutions designed for non-resident founders. Fortunately, several excellent options exist.

Mercury Bank: The Best Starting Point

Mercury is the leading banking platform for startups and non-resident business owners. It is FDIC-insured, requires no physical U.S. address or in-person visit, and opens entirely online. You will need your EIN, Articles of Organization, and a passport for identity verification.

Mercury provides a full U.S. checking account with routing and account numbers, a debit card, virtual cards for online spending, wire transfer capabilities, ACH payments, and integrations with Stripe, QuickBooks, and other tools. There is no minimum balance and no monthly fees for the basic account.

Relay: The Business Finance Alternative

Relay is another excellent option for non-resident LLCs. It offers multiple accounts, team spending controls, and clean bookkeeping integrations. Like Mercury, it opens online without an in-person visit and is FDIC-insured.

Wise Business: Your Bridge Account

Wise Business (formerly TransferWise) is not a traditional bank, but it is one of the most powerful tools for African entrepreneurs. With a Wise Business account, you can hold and convert money in over 40 currencies, receive payments locally in the U.S., UK, EU, Australia, and more, and transfer money internationally at real exchange rates with minimal fees.

Wise is ideal as a secondary account for receiving payments in multiple currencies and converting them efficiently before moving funds home. You can receive USD, GBP, EUR, AUD, and CAD via local bank details, effectively having bank accounts in five countries simultaneously.

Stripe: Your Payment Processing Engine

Stripe is the world's most developer-friendly payment processor. With a U.S. LLC and EIN, you can create a Stripe account that accepts credit cards, debit cards, bank transfers, and dozens of alternative payment methods from customers anywhere in the world. Stripe supports over 135 currencies and pays out to your Mercury or Relay account in USD.

To open Stripe, you need: a U.S. LLC, an EIN, a U.S. bank account (Mercury or Relay), a U.S. address (virtual address acceptable), your passport, and a valid website or business description.

Stripe Atlas: The Fast Track

Stripe Atlas is a formation service that registers your Wyoming or Delaware LLC, obtains your EIN, creates your Stripe account, and sets up your Mercury bank account in a single streamlined process. If you want maximum speed and minimal friction, Stripe Atlas is worth the fee.

Collecting International Payments

With your Stripe account active, you can collect payments globally through several mechanisms:

Stripe Payment Links

Create a no-code payment page in minutes. Share the link via email, WhatsApp, or social media. Customers pay with a card or bank transfer, and funds land in your U.S. bank account. Perfect for service businesses and consultants.

Stripe Invoices

Send professional invoices directly from Stripe with a payment link embedded. Track payment status, send reminders, and sync to your accounting software automatically.

Stripe Checkout

Embed a conversion-optimized checkout on your website. Supports subscriptions, one-time payments, and dozens of payment methods including Apple Pay, Google Pay, and local options.

Stripe Connect

If you are building a platform or marketplace, Stripe Connect lets you accept payments on behalf of third parties and route funds accordingly. Used by companies like Lyft, Shopify, and Fiverr.

Transferring Money Back to Your Home Country

Once money is in your U.S. account, moving it home efficiently is critical. The best options are:

Method	Best For
Wise	Real exchange rates, low fees, 1–2 day transfers
Grey (Africa-focused)	Built for African founders, USD to NGN/GHS/KES
Geegpay	Nigerian-focused, USD account + local transfers
Payoneer	Widely available across Africa, USD account
SWIFT Wire	Via Mercury to your African bank, 2–5 days, higher fees

CHAPTER 6

Taxes & Compliance: What Every African Business Owner Must Know

Taxes are the topic that causes the most anxiety, and the most costly mistakes. Let's be direct: operating a U.S. LLC as a non-resident does not automatically mean you owe U.S. taxes. But it does mean you have filing obligations, and ignoring them can result in serious penalties.

The Core Principle: Effectively Connected Income

The U.S. IRS taxes non-resident LLC owners on income that is 'Effectively Connected' with a U.S. trade or business. If you are a Nigerian entrepreneur running a software agency, selling digital products to clients in the UK and Australia, banking through Mercury, and you have no employees, no office, and perform no services while physically in the United States, your income is likely not effectively connected. You may owe zero U.S. federal income tax.

However, you must still file the correct information returns to document this fact.

Non-Filing Penalty Warning

The IRS imposes a \$25,000 penalty per year for failure to file Form 5472. This is one of the most commonly missed obligations by foreign-owned U.S. LLCs. The filing is not optional even if your income is zero.

State Taxes

Most states do not tax foreign income of non-resident-owned LLCs with no in-state operations. Wyoming has no state income tax. Delaware has no income tax for LLCs that conduct no business in Delaware (which is your situation if operating from Africa).

The one state-level obligation to note is Delaware's annual franchise tax, and Wyoming's annual report fee. These must be paid each year to keep your company in good standing.

Double Taxation Treaties

The United States has tax treaties with several African countries, including Egypt, Morocco, South Africa, and Tunisia. If your country has a treaty, it may reduce or eliminate withholding tax on certain income types. Check the IRS Tax Treaty Tables or consult a tax professional familiar with your home country's treaty status.

Hiring a Professional

Given the penalties involved, working with a U.S. CPA who specializes in non-resident taxation is strongly recommended. Look for CPAs who advertise services to 'foreign-owned LLCs' or 'non-resident business owners.'

Your Home Country Tax Obligations

This guide cannot cover every African country's tax regime, but one principle applies everywhere: you must report foreign income to your home country's tax authority. Whether in Nigeria (FIRS), Kenya (KRA), Ghana (GRA), or South Africa (SARS), foreign income from a U.S. entity is typically taxable in your country of residence. Consult a local tax advisor.

CHAPTER 7

Visas & Physical Presence: Can You Actually Work in the U.S.?

Here is a question that confuses many African entrepreneurs: If I own a U.S. company, can I work in the United States? The short answer is: owning a U.S. company does not give you the right to live or work in America. You need a visa. But there are legal pathways, and they are more accessible than many people think.

What You Can Do Without a Visa

As a non-resident owner of a U.S. LLC, you can legally operate your company remotely from Africa. You can sign contracts, receive payments, manage bank accounts, hire U.S. contractors, and run your business, all without ever entering the United States.

If you visit the U.S. as a tourist on a B-1/B-2 visa or ESTA (for eligible countries), you can attend meetings, visit clients, and conduct negotiation activities for a limited period. You cannot perform 'work' in the traditional sense, and you cannot be paid for services rendered on U.S. soil under a tourist visa.

Relevant Visa Categories

E-2 Treaty Investor Visa

If you are a citizen of a country with an E-2 treaty with the U.S. (including Nigeria, Kenya, Ethiopia, Cameroon, and others), you can apply for an E-2 visa by investing a 'substantial amount' in your U.S. business. This allows you to live and work in the U.S. while managing your investment.

O-1 Extraordinary Ability Visa

If you have achieved extraordinary recognition in your field, major awards, significant media coverage, a demonstrated record of excellence, the O-1 visa is available. It is competitive but achievable for established African tech founders and creative professionals.

L-1 Intracompany Transfer

If you own both a U.S. company and a company in your home country, and you have worked for the home company for at least one year, you may qualify for an L-1 transfer visa to work in the U.S. entity as an executive or manager. This is a popular route for established African business owners expanding internationally.

EB-5 Investor Visa (Green Card)

The EB-5 program grants permanent residency (a green card) in exchange for a qualifying investment of at least \$800,000 in a U.S. business that creates jobs. This is a longer-term path, not a startup tool, but worth knowing exists.

Practical Advice

Most African entrepreneurs running U.S. LLCs do so entirely from their home country and never need a U.S. work visa. The need for physical presence depends entirely on your business model. If you plan to build a team, office, or significant U.S. operations, consult an immigration attorney early.

CHAPTER 8

Building Your Brand & Online Presence in the U.S.

A U.S. entity without a credible online presence is a missed opportunity. Your digital storefront (website, domain, email, social profiles) is often the first thing American clients check before trusting you with their money. Building this credibly is not expensive; it requires strategic thinking.

Your Domain and Website

Secure a .com domain that matches or closely resembles your company name. A .com domain carries more international authority than country-specific extensions.

Your website must do three things: establish credibility, communicate your value proposition clearly, and make it easy for potential clients to take action (contact, schedule a call, buy).

Professional U.S. Contact Details

Your U.S. presence should feel real. This means:

- A U.S. phone number
- A professional email with your domain (yourname@yourcompany.com)
- A U.S. mailing address (virtual mailbox service, see Chapter 4)
- A LinkedIn company page with complete information

Content That Builds Trust

American clients hire people they trust, and trust is built through demonstrated expertise. Publish case studies, write about problems you solve, create short videos, and share insights on LinkedIn. Content marketing is the most cost-effective trust-building tool for an international founder.

One well-written case study showing how you helped a client get a specific result is worth more than any advertising campaign.

Marketplaces and Platforms

If you are a service provider, marketplaces are an excellent first step into the U.S. market. Consider:

Platform	Best For
Toptal	Top 3% of freelancers, high rates, rigorous vetting
Upwork	Broad market access, competitive, good for portfolio building
Contra	Commission-free, growing platform for independent consultants

Platform	Best For
Lemon.io	Developer-focused, startup clients, curated matching
LinkedIn Services	Professional service listings, visible to your network

Payment Checkout on Your Website

Once your Stripe account is active, embed Stripe Checkout or create Stripe Payment Links for your website. This allows any client anywhere in the world, to pay you in their local currency while you receive USD in your Mercury account. The conversion is automatic and the payout schedule is predictable (2 business days after charge).

CHAPTER 9

Contracts, Liability & Legal Foundations for Your U.S. Business

The legal layer of your U.S. business is what protects you when deals go wrong, and deals do go wrong. A solid legal foundation is not paranoia; it is professional infrastructure. You do not need to spend thousands of dollars on lawyers to start, but you do need the basics in place from day one.

Why Your LLC Structure Protects You

The entire purpose of an LLC is to separate your personal assets from business liability. If your company is sued, creditors can only come after company assets, not your personal bank account, home, or car. This protection is called the 'corporate veil,' and it holds as long as you run your business properly.

To maintain liability protection: keep business and personal finances completely separate, sign contracts as the company (not yourself personally), document major business decisions, and never use business funds for personal expenses without proper documentation.

Essential Contracts You Need

Client Service Agreement

Every client engagement should begin with a signed contract. It should define the scope of work, payment terms, revision policy, intellectual property ownership, confidentiality, and what happens if either party terminates the agreement.

Independent Contractor Agreement

When you hire freelancers or sub-contractors, use a written agreement. This protects you from misclassification issues and makes clear who owns the work product.

Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA)

Before sharing sensitive business information with potential partners, investors, or employees, have them sign an NDA. Mutual NDAs (both parties agree to keep each other's info confidential) are standard in professional settings.

Terms of Service and Privacy Policy

If you have a website, especially one that collects email addresses, sells products, or runs any kind of SaaS, you need Terms of Service and a Privacy Policy. Use a lawyer to generate compliant documents. This is especially important if you serve EU customers (GDPR) or California residents (CCPA).

Intellectual Property Ownership

When you create something (software, a brand, written content, a logo), it has value. Protect it.

- Trademark your brand name and logo with the USPTO once you have revenue
- Use copyright notices on all original written and creative work
- Ensure your contracts assign IP ownership to your company, not to you personally or to contractors

Dispute Resolution

U.S. litigation is expensive. Most contracts for small businesses should specify mandatory arbitration or mediation as the first step for dispute resolution. Include a governing law clause (specify which state's law applies, usually your state of formation) and a jurisdiction clause.

CHAPTER 10

Your Launch Plan: From Decision to Open for Business in 90 Days

This is where everything comes together. The following 90-day plan is designed for an African entrepreneur who is starting from scratch and wants to be fully operational (entity formed, banking active, Stripe live, website up, first client reached) in 90 days. It is aggressive but achievable.

Days 1–14: Foundation

1. Decide on state (Delaware, Wyoming, or New Mexico) and entity type (LLC or C-Corp)
2. Check your chosen company name on the Secretary of State's website
3. Select and pay for a registered agent service
4. File Articles of Organization
5. Once Articles are approved, apply for your EIN
6. Get a lawyer to draft your Operating Agreement and keep it on file
7. Set up a virtual U.S. mailbox

Days 15–30: Banking & Payments

8. Apply for a bank account (have EIN, Articles, passport ready)
9. Apply for a secondary account (optional but recommended)
10. Set up a Business account for multi-currency holding
11. Create your Stripe account using your EIN, account details, and U.S. address
12. Create your first Stripe Payment Link, even if you have no product yet, test it
13. Set up with your domain email
14. Purchase your U.S. phone number

Days 31–60: Brand & Legal

15. Purchase your .com domain and set up website
16. Write and publish your website's homepage, services page, and contact page
17. Get a lawyer to draft a Client Service Agreement template
18. Get a lawyer to draft a Privacy Policy and Terms of Service
19. Create your LinkedIn company page and optimize your personal profile
20. Set up your accounting software
21. Create an account for proposals and contracts

Days 61–90: Revenue & Operations

22. Identify and reach out to potential clients or referral partners
23. Publish your first piece of content (case study, article, or LinkedIn post)
24. Send your first proposal

25. Book a consultation with a U.S. CPA who handles non-resident LLC taxes
26. Set up your annual compliance calendar: Form 5472 due date, state annual report due date
27. Join one relevant online community
28. Close your first U.S. client and collect your first international payment

The Mindset That Makes This Work

Every African entrepreneur who has built a globally competitive business from the continent has had to overcome the same friction you face today: doubt (from themselves and others), limited access to information, and a system that was not designed with them in mind. The formation process described in this book is not theoretical, it is the exact path taken by hundreds of successful African founders.

The U.S. market does not care where you were born. It cares whether you show up professionally, deliver reliably, and make doing business with you easy. A U.S. LLC, a Stripe account, and a Mercury bank account make you easy to do business with. The rest is your talent, and you already have that.

Now go build something the world will remember.

REFERENCE

Quick Glossary of U.S. Business Terms

Term	Definition
LLC	Limited Liability Company. Flexible business entity that separates personal and business liability.
C-Corp	C-Corporation. Standard corporate form preferred by U.S. venture investors.
EIN	Employer Identification Number. Your company's federal tax ID, issued by the IRS.
IRS	Internal Revenue Service. The U.S. federal tax authority.
ITIN	Individual Taxpayer Identification Number. A personal tax ID for non-U.S. residents. Not needed for EIN.
Registered Agent	A person or service that receives legal documents on behalf of your LLC.
Articles of Organization	The formation document filed with a state to create an LLC.
Operating Agreement	Internal document governing LLC ownership and operations.
Form 5472	Annual IRS filing required for foreign-owned U.S. LLCs. \$25,000 penalty if missed.
Form W-8BEN-E	Certifies foreign status to payment processors and banks.
FDIC	Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation. Insures U.S. bank deposits up to \$250,000.
ACH	Automated Clearing House. Electronic bank transfer system used in the U.S.
Stripe	Global payment processing platform requiring a U.S. entity for full access.
Mercury	Online-first U.S. business bank popular with non-resident founders.
Wise Business	Multi-currency account platform for international money management.
DBA	'Doing Business As.' A trade name different from your legal company name.

Term	Definition
Foreign Qualify	Register your LLC in an additional state where you have physical operations.
Corporate Veil	Legal protection separating your personal assets from business liabilities.
USPTO	United States Patent and Trademark Office. Where you register trademarks.
GDPR	EU data protection regulation. Applies if you serve European customers.